



Ashes reverie: David Gower, England's debonair captain, stands tall on the Oval balcony, cradling the Ashes urn — the gleaming symbol of a summer triumph. The 3-1 series win in 1985 is his crowning moment. Beside him, Allan Border embodies the stoic dignity of defeat. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

carving out windows for franchise cricket. Now, those same people are saying we need a dedicated window for Test cricket.

And it's complicated, isn't it? There are so many factors — money, resources, infrastructure. Lord's is an exception: 28,000 people will turn up on a Monday for Day Five of a Test if the match is set up well. India still gets good crowds, though in a 100,000-seater, 30,000 can look sparse. Australia gets healthy numbers when we tour. But in the West Indies, the stands are nearly empty. Test matches there often lose money.

In New Zealand, they've at least adapted by using smaller grounds to make things feel fuller. But for many boards, the arithmetic doesn't work. You can understand why a board like Cricket West Indies, already under pressure, might prefer eight days of white-ball cricket over 15 days of loss-making Tests. That's a hard call to argue with.

So, unless the ICC can think of — I know it wouldn't go down well in India — redistributing the funds that can help out the poorer nations, we

will see Test cricket declining apart from the top three, four, five nations. (This can't be) just an odd boost every other year or in three or four years, but year by year. So I'm not the Solomon who can tell you exactly how to solve this. But one of the things I do think very strongly is that if you want Test-playing nations to still be in business, then they need help.

With Bazball's rise, England's pitches seem flatter and more batting-friendly than before. Is old-school English cricket losing its edge?

(Smiles) I suppose these flat pitches suit Stokes' desire to chase — well, sometimes.

Even this England team would

agree that a better contest between bat and ball makes for a better spectacle. That's been a mantra for so many of us over the years. Watching teams pile up 600 on certain flat pitches — it gets quite dull, doesn't it?

Then there's the commercial side to consider. Take this Lord's Test: if it finishes in three days, that's potentially two days of lost revenue. But how do you weigh that against the quality of entertainment the crowd has already had?

The dream is a fair contest, something in it for both batters and bowlers.

A game that lasts at least four days, stays tight, and builds toward a tense finish, like this one. That's when Test cricket is at its best.

« The idea of batting positively isn't new. England has just taken it to new heights »